

THE SWEET LIFE

Italy has a new luxury train. The stunning La Dolce Vita Orient Express draws inspiration from mid-century modern Italian design and offers itineraries based around wine, heritage, cuisine and golf, with dreamy names like 'The Truffle Route' and 'Tastes of Tuscan Vineyards'. Most departures are from Rome and take in major Italian destinations, including Sicily, which is accessed via a passenger rail ferry. From 4,160 euros per passenger per night; see www.orient-express.com/la-dolce-vita.

FREEDOM PASS

On June 18, Union road transport and roadways minister Nitin Gadkari announced a FASTag-based Annual Pass for hassle-free highway travel. Set for launch on August 15, 2025, the pass is priced at ₹3,000, and is valid for one year from the date of activation or up to 200 trips–whichever comes first. This is exclusively for non-commercial private vehicles such as cars, jeeps and vans, and aims to reduce wait times, ease congestion, and minimise disputes at toll plazas.



Niraamaya has launched 'sleep retreats' at its properties in Kovalam and Kumarakom. Check in for 7 nights at Niraamaya Retreats Surya Samudra, Kovalam, or Niraamaya Retreats Backwaters & Beyond, Kumarakom, to escape the stress of daily life and experience unparalleled relaxation. The rejuvenating programme combines Ayurvedic therapies, yoga and mindfulness to improve sleep quality and restore balance, and includes daily treatments like Abhyangam, Shirodhara and Udwarthana, along with nourishing Ayurvedic meals. Now might be a good time, given the month of Karkidakam (mid-July to mid-August)—supposed to be excellent for getting the maximum benefits from Ayurveda treatments—is almost upon us. From Rs 1.75 lakh plus taxes for 7 nights on single occupancy; see www.niraamaya.com.



SHUTTERSTOCK

Compiled by Amit Dixit